SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #38 · FORGIVENESS

“Forgiving means I must trust them again.”

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Where it often comes from

Being told to “forgive and forget” after being hurt or abused. Pressure to restore a relationship quickly so things look peaceful. Confusing forgiveness with reconciliation. Fear that setting limits makes you unforgiving. Past experiences where forgiving led to being hurt again.

What Scripture teaches

Forgiveness and trust are different. Forgiveness is releasing a debt and leaving justice to God; it can be given even when the other person has not changed. Trust is earned over time through changed behavior. Scripture tells us to forgive as God forgave us, and also to guard our hearts, to be wise as serpents, and to live at peace with others “if it is possible.” You can forgive someone and still keep healthy boundaries for your safety.

> *“If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone”* **(Romans 12:18)**.

Also see

> “Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you” **(Ephesians 4:32)**.

> “Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life” **(Proverbs 4:23)**.

> “Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves” **(Matthew 10:16)**.

> “Do not avenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God’s wrath. For it is written: ‘Vengeance is Mine; I will repay, says the Lord.’” **(Romans 12:19)**.

Common self-statements

- If I really forgave, I’d let them back in.
- Setting limits means I haven’t forgiven.
- A good Christian trusts everyone again.
- I have to act like nothing happened.
- If I keep my distance, I’m holding a grudge.
- Forgiving means letting them hurt me again.

Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you must either fully trust or not forgive at all.
- **Confusing terms:** Treating forgiveness, trust, and reconciliation as the same thing.
- **Should statements:** “I should trust them because I’m a Christian.”
- **Ignoring evidence:** Overlooking whether the person has actually changed.

Challenging questions

- Is forgiveness the same as trust?

- What does “if it is possible on your part” suggest about peace?
- Has this person shown changed behavior over time?
- Does guarding my heart mean I am unforgiving?
- Can I release my desire for revenge and still keep a safe distance?
- Who told me forgiveness means trusting again?
- What would healthy boundaries look like here?

Truth summary

> Forgiving someone does not mean I must trust them again. I can release the debt and leave justice to God, while still guarding my heart and keeping healthy boundaries. Trust is rebuilt only through changed behavior over time. I can forgive as God forgave me and still be wise.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgive
- Wisdom
- Friendship
- Vengeance
- Protection

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Forgiving means I must trust them again"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Forgiving means I must trust them again." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Is forgiveness the same as trust?
- ☐ What does "if it is possible" mean for me?
- ☐ Has this person changed over time?
- ☐ Does guarding my heart make me unforgiving?
- ☐ Can I forgive and still keep my distance?
- ☐ What healthy boundary do I need?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness and trust are not the same.
- ☐ I can forgive and still keep healthy boundaries.
- ☐ Trust is earned through changed behavior.
- ☐ I can leave justice to God.
- ☐ Guarding my heart is wise, not unforgiving.
- ☐ I can be kind and still be careful.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Romans 12:18**
  "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone."
- [ ] **Ephesians 4:32**
  "Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you."
- [ ] **Proverbs 4:23**
  "Guard your heart with all diligence, for from it flow springs of life."
- [ ] **Matthew 10:16**
  "Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves."
- [ ] **Romans 12:19**
  "Do not avenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God's wrath. For it is written: 'Vengeance is Mine; I will repay, says the Lord.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Boundary log:** Each day, write one way I chose not to seek revenge and one boundary I kept.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Romans 12:18 becomes: "If it is possible on **Sarah's** part, **she** will live at peace with everyone."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Forgive" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write two lists:** "What forgiveness means for me" and "What trust would require from them." Notice the difference.
- ☐ **Pray a simple prayer releasing the debt to God,** without promising to restore the relationship yet.
- ☐ **Decide on one healthy boundary** and write down how you will keep it calmly.
- ☐ **If you have been abused, talk with a counselor or pastor** about safety and forgiveness.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Forgiving means I must trust them again": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One boundary I kept with kindness
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Forgiving means I must trust them again.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for forgiving me so fully. Help me forgive others as You forgave me, and help me reject the lie that forgiving means I must trust them again. Give me wisdom to guard my heart, courage to keep healthy boundaries, and peace as I leave justice in Your hands. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.